KASHIGO · AUDIOBOOK COMPANION

India Scam-Proof

Listener's Quick Reference

Some things are better seen than heard. These are the pages from the book you will want open on your phone in India:

- The Scripts: Hindi phrases to say no, bargain and ask prices
- The Price Tables: fair 2026 prices, incl. Varanasi specials
- If You Do Get Scammed: key numbers and what to do
- Your Pre-Departure Checklist

Listen to the chapter, then keep this card for the moment you need it. Save it to your phone. It works offline.

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CHAPTER 11

The Scripts

These are the phrases I would teach a friend arriving in India for the first time. You do not need perfect pronunciation. Even a few words of Hindi change the tone of an interaction completely — the person in front of you instantly understands that you are not totally new, and the "tourist price" often drops on the spot.

Hindi is widely understood across North India, and in tourist areas elsewhere. In the South (Kerala, for example), English often works better than Hindi; use the English versions there.

A note on grammar: a few Hindi verbs change with the speaker's gender. Where it matters I give both: the first is what a man says, the second what a woman says.

Saying no

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
No thank you, I'm fine.	Nahi, shukriya.	The all-purpose polite no
I don't want it.	Nahi chahiye.	For touts, sellers, unwanted help
I really don't want it.	Bilkul nahi chahiye.	When the first no didn't work
Leave it / never mind.	Rehne dijiye.	Ending a negotiation politely
Please don't follow me.	Mere peechhe mat aaiye.	Firm, clear
Go away.	Jaao. / Chalo, jaao.	Blunt; use only if needed
I'm just looking.	Bas dekh raha hoon / rahi hoon.	In shops, at ghats
I don't need a guide.	Guide nahi chahiye.	At monuments
I already have a booking.	Booking ho chuki hai.	For hotel and taxi touts

Asking prices and negotiating

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
How much is it?	Kitne ka hai?	Prices of things
How much to [place]?	[Place] tak kitna?	Autos, rickshaws
That's too much.	Bahut zyada hai.	Your first reaction to any quote
Tell me the right price.	Sahi daam bataiye.	Signals you know the game
Final price?	Last kitna?	Asking for their best

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
I'll give [100].	Main [sau] doonga / doongi.	Your counter-offer
OK, done.	Theek hai, pakka.	Agreeing a price
Total, for both of us.	Total, dono ke liye.	Avoiding per-person tricks
Give it at MRP.	MRP pe dijiye.	Packaged goods
I need change.	Change chahiye. / Khulle chahiye.	When a seller "has no change"
The rest of the money?	Baaki paise?	When change is short

Transport

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
Go by the meter.	Meter se chalo.	Autos and taxis
Go straight to [place].	Seedha [place] chalo.	Prevents detours
No shops.	Koi dukaan nahi.	Before the ride starts
Stop here.	Yahan rokiye.	Getting out
Slowly, please.	Dheere chaliye.	Fast drivers
Go to this address.	Is address pe chalo.	Showing your map
Payment through the app.	App se payment hoga.	App cabs asking for cash

At the river, temples and shops

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
One hour, private boat, how much?	Ek ghanta, private boat, kitne ka?	Varanasi ghats

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
Pay at the end.	Paise baad mein.	Boats, guides
No stops, only the river.	Koi stop nahi, sirf ghat.	Before boarding
No photos?	Photo mana hai?	Asking if photos are allowed
May I take a photo?	Photo le sakta hoon / sakti hoon?	Always ask first
How much for the shoes?	Joote rakhne ka kitna?	Shoe-minding
Give me a receipt.	Receipt dijiye.	Fines, donations, purchases

Help and emergencies

English	Hindi (romanised)	Meaning / when to use
Help!	Bachao!	Emergency
Call the police.	Police ko bulao.	Emergency
Where is the police station?	Thana kahaan hai?	Reporting a problem
I need a doctor.	Mujhe doctor chahiye.	Illness, injury
Get back!	Peechhe hato!	Harassment; say it loudly
What are you doing?	Kya kar rahe ho?	Harassment; draws attention
Show me your ID.	Apna ID dikhaiye.	Fake officials, fake checkers

Kindness phrases (use these the most)

English	Hindi (romanised)
Hello / greetings	Namaste

English	Hindi (romanised)
Thank you	Dhanyavaad / Shukriya
Very good / delicious	Bahut achha / Bahut badhiya
Brother / sister (friendly address)	Bhaiya / Didi
Uncle / aunty (respectful address for elders)	Uncle-ji / Aunty-ji
Excuse me / sorry	Maaf kijiye

LOCAL TIP

Call your auto driver "bhaiya" (brother) and the woman selling flowers "didi" (sister). It is how locals speak. It is warm, it is respectful, and it changes the price more than you would believe.



CHAPTER 12

The Price Tables

Every price here is **approximate for 2026 — verify locally**. Prices vary by city, season, time of day and how far you are from a famous monument. Use these as a fair-price compass: if a quote is within or near the range, accept it gracefully; if it is double or triple, you have room to negotiate or walk.

Getting around

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Delhi airport to central Delhi, prepaid taxi	500–900	More at night and for bigger cars
Varanasi airport to city, prepaid taxi	800–1,000	Final stretch on foot into the old city

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Short auto ride (2–3 km) in North Indian cities	80–200	Check the app fare as a benchmark
Longer auto ride (5–8 km)	200–400	More in Delhi, Mumbai and Goa
Short cycle rickshaw ride (1–2 km)	50–150	Pay more in heat or with luggage
Car with driver, per day (Golden Triangle, sedan)	2,500–4,500	Ask what is included; varies by distance
Station porter, couple of bags	100–300	Agree before lifting
Scooter rental per day (Goa)	300–600	Season dependent; deposit extra

Food and drink

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Cup of chai at a street stall	10–30	More in cafés
Bottled water (1 litre)	MRP, usually ~20	Never pay above MRP
Street snack (samosa, kachori)	15–50	Per piece or plate
Simple thali at a local restaurant	100–300	Unlimited refills at many places
Meal at a mid-range tourist restaurant	400–1,000 per person	More in Goa, Mumbai, upscale areas
Lassi	40–120	More at famous shops

Varanasi specials

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Private hand-rowed boat, 2–4 people	800–1,500 per hour	Agree price, duration, route first
Shared boat, per person	30–100	Organised shared tours cost more
Entry to any ghat	Free	There is no ghat ticket
Sadhu photo	20–50	Only if you asked first
Diya (floating lamp) offering	10–30	Lovely tradition after aarti
Shoe-minding at a temple	10–20	Many temples are free
Simple blessing / puja offering	50–200	Agree before it starts

Sights and services

Item	Fair range (Rs)	Notes
Taj Mahal, foreigners (incl. mausoleum)	About 1,300	Official ASI price; closed Fridays; verify online
Licensed guide, half day	1,000–2,500	Varies by city and language
Tourist SIM card with a month of data	300–1,000	Airports often charge more
Laundry (per item, guesthouse)	20–60	Often cheaper by weight
Shoe shine	30–100	Agree first



CHAPTER 13

If You Do Get Scammed

Even careful travellers get caught sometimes. I have been overcharged in my own city. If it happens to you, the most important thing is to stay safe, act quickly where money can be recovered, and not let one bad experience colour the rest of your trip.

First: safety, then money

If you feel threatened, stop arguing. No amount of money is worth an escalating confrontation. Pay if you must, get to a safe, busy place, and deal with it afterwards. Your safety is the only thing that cannot be refunded.

Key numbers (save these now)

Service	Number	Notes
All emergencies (police, fire, ambulance)	112	Works nationwide; also via the 112 India app
India Tourism helpline	1363 or 1800-11-1363	Toll-free, 24/7, multiple languages; verify before travel
Cyber crime and online fraud	1930	Also report online at cybercrime.gov.in
Women's helplines (many states)	1091 / 181	Availability varies by state
Your embassy or consulate	Look it up before you go	Save the emergency number

Tourist police

Many tourist states — including Rajasthan, Goa, Uttar Pradesh (Agra and Varanasi), Kerala and Delhi — have tourist police units, often stationed at major sights, railway stations and ghats. They are used to dealing with foreign visitors, and they can often resolve small disputes (an auto driver refusing to give change, a boatman demanding more than agreed) on the spot. Look for a booth or ask any police officer.

Reporting a crime

For theft, a lost passport, or fraud, file a police complaint (called an FIR — First Information Report — for serious matters). Ask for a copy; you will need it for insurance claims and for a replacement passport. Under Indian law, police can register a "zero FIR" for a cognisable offence regardless of where it happened, so you should not be turned away just because you are at the "wrong" station. Bring your passport, visa, and any evidence: photos, receipts, screenshots, phone numbers, vehicle numbers.

Card fraud and chargebacks

If you were charged by card for something fraudulent — a fake gem deal, a shipped parcel that never arrived, a payment you did not authorise:

1. **Call your card issuer immediately** using the number on the back of your card or in your banking app. Freeze or cancel the card.
2. **Ask about a chargeback.** Card networks have dispute processes for goods not received, goods not as described and fraud. Time limits apply — often a few months, sometimes less — so act fast.
3. **Collect evidence**: receipts, invoices, messages, photos, the shop's name and address, and a police report if you have one.
4. **Write down what happened** while it is fresh: dates, times, names and what was promised.

Cash and UPI payments are much harder to recover, which is one more reason to pay by card for any large purchase.

Lost or stolen passport

Report it to the police, get a copy of the report, and contact your embassy or consulate for an emergency travel document. You will also need to deal with India's immigration authorities for an exit permit or visa transfer in some cases; your embassy will guide you through it.

Leave a review

When it is safe and you are back home, leave an honest, factual review of a business that cheated you — and a glowing one for the people who helped you. Reviews genuinely shape the tourism economy in India, and they protect the next traveller.

Then let it go

The worst outcome of a scam is not the lost money. It is the lost trust that stops you talking to the next friendly stranger — who may be the one who invites you to a family wedding, or shows you the best lassi in town. Learn the lesson, then open your heart again.



Your Pre-Departure Checklist

Tick these off in the week before you fly.

Documents and money

- E-visa applied for **only** at indianvisaonline.gov.in, approved and printed
- Passport valid for at least six months, plus photocopies and a digital copy in secure cloud storage
- Travel insurance with medical cover, checked and saved
- Two debit or credit cards from different banks; bank told about your travel
- Plan for rupees on arrival (airport ATM or exchange counter)
- Checked the current status of UPI One World for foreign visitors

Phone and apps

- Uber, Ola (and optionally Rapido) installed and set up
- IRCTC app installed; account registered if you plan train travel
- Offline Google Maps downloaded for your first city
- First hotel address and phone saved as a screenshot
- 112, 1363, 1930 and your embassy's number saved
- Live location sharing set up with someone at home

Bookings

- First two nights booked through a reputable platform or directly
- Airport pickup arranged, or plan for the prepaid taxi counter
- Hotel messaged with your arrival time
- Any long train journeys booked (Foreign Tourist Quota where available)

Health

- Travel clinic visited (vaccines, malaria advice, medicines)
- Hand sanitiser, ORS sachets, insect repellent, any prescription medicines in original packaging
- Reusable water bottle

In your head

- The one rule: unasked help plus an information gap means slow down
- "Nahi chahiye, shukriya" — practised out loud at least once
- Agree price, duration and route before any ride
- Never shop where you were taken
- Never share an OTP

- The ghats are free